

The Perfection of Wisdom in a Single Syllable, the Mother of All Tathāgatas

Ekākṣarī Mātā Nāma Sarvatathāgata Prajñāpāramitā · Toh 23 · Derge Kangyur

དེ་མེ་ཞེ་གཤམ་པ་ཐམས་ཅད་ཀྱི་ཤེ་རབ་ཀྱི་རལ་ཏུ་ཕྱུ་པ་ཡི་གེ་ཅེ་མ་ཞེ་བ་བྱ

Toh 23 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in English as "The Perfection of Wisdom in a Single Syllable, the Mother of All Tathāgatas," in Sanskrit as the Eka Akṣarī Mātā Nāma Sarva Tathāgata Prajñāpāramitā, and in Tibetan as the Deshyin shekpa thamché kyi yum yigé chungngü shyewawa. It belongs to the Perfection of Wisdom, or Prajñāpāramitā, class of texts — a body of Mahāyāna literature concerned with the nature of wisdom and emptiness as the path to awakening. This remarkably concise sūtra takes the form of a teaching given by the Buddha on Vulture Peak at Rājagṛha, addressed to his attendant Ānanda, in which the entirety of the Perfection of Wisdom is distilled into a single syllable for the benefit of all sentient beings. As Toh 23 in the Kangyur, it is counted among the canonical scriptures preserved in the Tibetan Buddhist tradition, sitting within the broader Prajñāpāramitā section of that collection.

They offered heartfelt praise to what the Blessed One had taught. The noble sūtra of the Great Vehicle known as the Perfection of Wisdom in Few Syllables is complete.

In the language of India: Eka Akṣarī Mātā Nāma Sarva Tathāgata Prajñāpāramitā. In the Tibetan language: The Perfection of Wisdom in a Single Syllable, the Mother of All Tathāgatas.

Homage to the Great Mother, the Perfection of Wisdom.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling on Vulture Peak mountain at Rājagṛha, together with a great Saṅgha of thirteen hundred monks and many tens of millions of bodhisattvas.

At that time the Blessed One spoke these words to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, take up this text called the Perfection of Wisdom in a Single Syllable for the benefit and happiness of sentient beings. It is this: A."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the venerable Ānanda, all those monks, and all those great bodhisattvas understood the perfection and, filled with joy, offered heartfelt praise to what the Blessed One had taught.

The text known as the Perfection of Wisdom in a Single Syllable, the Mother of All Tathāgatas, is complete.

Translator's Notes

- The single syllable "A" is the entire content of this Perfection of Wisdom teaching. In Indo-Tibetan tradition the syllable A represents emptiness, the unborn nature of all phenomena, and the primordial ground of the Perfection of Wisdom, so its presentation here as the complete teaching is doctrinally intentional rather than textually defective.

The opening phrase of this passage completes a preceding colophon from the shorter Perfection of Wisdom text, then the longer title-sūtra begins fresh. The translation renders both sequences in order as they appear.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.